



PIONEER

THE TRAILBLAZER

Zone: The Bridge

Document P3

OD9 PROGRESSION SYSTEM



Why Rotation

Most organizations let people specialize. You're the mentorship person. She's the operations person. He's the strategy person.

We rotate. Here's why:

Prevents burnout. Mentorship is emotionally draining. Operations is detail-heavy. Strategy is ambiguity-heavy. Doing any one thing forever exhausts specific muscles. Rotation gives muscles time to recover.

Distributes knowledge. If only one person knows how governance facilitation works, you have a single point of failure. Rotation means everyone can do everything. The organization doesn't collapse if someone steps away.

Builds empathy. It's easy to criticize the operations person when you've never done operations. It's harder when you know exactly how tedious those tracking spreadsheets are. Rotation creates mutual understanding.

Develops breadth. Pioneer-to-Benefactor transition requires organizational overview. You can't oversee the whole if you've only ever touched one part.

The Rotation System

Pioneers cycle through five roles. Each rotation is approximately **4-6 weeks**, adjusted based on:

- Ongoing projects (don't switch mid-mentor relationship)
- Community needs (surge in new Architects might keep mentors in place longer)
- Individual requests (short-term flexibility for personal circumstances)

Rotations are coordinated so coverage remains consistent. Never zero Pioneers in a role.

Role 1: Mentorship

What You Do

Guide Architects through their capstone projects.

Responsibilities:

- Review capstone proposals (Part 1)
- Provide feedback during implementation
- Answer questions and unblock stuck Architects
- Conduct feedback discussions (Part 2 reviews)
- Participate in Handoff Ceremonies (Part 3)

Time commitment: 3-5 hours/week when mentees are active.

How to Do It Well

Be available, not hovering. Weekly check-ins are enough. Don't micromanage. Let them struggle productively - that's how learning happens.

Ask questions more than give answers. "What approaches have you tried?" teaches more than "Do it this way."

Calibrate feedback to the individual. Some people need encouragement. Some need direct criticism. Some need detailed guidance. Some need to be left alone. Read your mentee.

Flag problems early. If a project is off-track at week 2, say something. Don't wait until week 8 when it's unsalvageable.

Model the behavior you want. Your mentees are watching how you handle things. Be the Pioneer you want them to become.

Common Mistakes

- **Over-helping.** Doing the work for them defeats the point.
- **Under-communicating.** Disappearing for two weeks is not mentorship.
- **Being too nice.** Feedback that avoids hard truths doesn't help.
- **Being too harsh.** Crushing people's motivation doesn't help either.
- **Projecting your path.** Their journey doesn't have to look like yours.

Role 2: Evaluation

What You Do

Review contribution quality. Assess proposal feasibility. Judge work outputs.

Responsibilities:

- Evaluate Architect capstone projects (does it meet quality standards?)
- Assess governance proposals (is this feasible? well-specified?)
- Review content submissions (is this publishable quality?)
- Resolve prediction markets (what actually happened?)
- Quality-check community outputs

Time commitment: 2-4 hours/week, variable based on queue.

How to Do It Well

Apply consistent standards. Your evaluation of Project A should use the same criteria as Project B. Write down your criteria.

Be specific in feedback. "This doesn't meet standards" is useless. "The documentation section is missing installation instructions and the tests don't cover the error paths" is useful.

Separate quality from preference. You might not like their approach, but that doesn't make it wrong. Evaluate against objective criteria, not your personal taste.

Document your decisions. Future evaluators will reference precedent. Write down why you approved or rejected things.

Be willing to say no. Approval inflation destroys the value of approval. If work isn't ready, it isn't ready.

Common Mistakes

- **Rubber-stamping.** Approving everything to avoid conflict.
- **Goal-post moving.** Adding new requirements after initial submission.
- **Inconsistency.** Approving similar work for person A and rejecting it for person B.
- **Cruelty.** Using evaluation as an opportunity to feel superior.
- **Delay.** Sitting on submissions for weeks without response.

Role 3: Strategic Planning

What You Do

Identify what decisions need to be made. Research options. Present findings.

Responsibilities:

- Maintain the decision pipeline (what's coming? what's blocked?)
- Draft proposals for major strategic choices
- Research options and present pros/cons
- Identify emerging issues before they become crises
- Connect current decisions to long-term strategy

Time commitment: 3-5 hours/week, spiky around major decisions.

How to Do It Well

Look ahead. Strategy isn't about today's fire. It's about what's coming in 3-6 months.

Research before proposing. Don't bring half-baked ideas. Do the work to understand the landscape.

Present options, not preferences. Your job is to lay out the choices clearly. Let governance decide. (You can have opinions, but separate them from your analysis.)

Consider second-order effects. What are the downstream consequences? Who else is affected?

Make decisions decidable. Frame choices clearly. What are the actual options? What information would change the calculus?

Common Mistakes

- **Analysis paralysis.** Researching forever, never bringing decisions forward.
- **Advocacy masquerading as analysis.** Presenting only the evidence for your preferred option.
- **Ignoring stakeholders.** Proposing changes without considering who's affected.
- **Overcomplicating.** Making decisions bigger than they need to be.
- **Underestimating implementation.** Beautiful strategies that can't actually be executed.

Role 4: Community Health

What You Do

Monitor sentiment. Prevent conflicts. Optimize experience.

Responsibilities:

- Track community engagement patterns
- Identify conflicts before they escalate
- Ensure governance decisions reflect community needs
- Optimize new member experience
- Monitor Pioneer engagement and address burnout risk

Time commitment: 3-4 hours/week, higher during community stress.

How to Do It Well

Listen more than you speak. Your job is to sense what's happening, not to fix everything yourself.

Build relationships across tiers. You need to know how Observers feel, not just what Pioneers think.

Intervene early and gently. Small conflicts addressed early stay small. Ignored conflicts become drama.

Don't triangulate. If person A has a problem with person B, encourage them to talk to each other. Don't become the messenger.

Track patterns, not just incidents. One complaint is an incident. Five similar complaints are a pattern.

Common Mistakes

- **Playing therapist.** You're not a mental health professional. Know when to escalate.
 - **Taking sides.** Community health means holding space for everyone, even people you disagree with.
 - **Over-optimizing for comfort.** Growth requires discomfort. Not all friction is bad.
 - **Gossip.** Information shared with you in confidence stays in confidence.
 - **Burnout.** Community health work is emotionally taxing. Watch yourself.
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Role 5: Operations

What You Do

Manage active processes. Coordinate implementation. Keep things running.

Responsibilities:

- Facilitate governance processes (manage Delphi rounds, track votes)
- Coordinate implementation of past decisions
- Report on what's working and what isn't
- Maintain governance documentation
- Handle administrative tasks that don't fit elsewhere

Time commitment: 4-6 hours/week, consistent.

How to Do It Well

Create systems, not heroics. If you're manually doing something every week, automate it or document it so others can share the load.

Close loops. Decisions without implementation are worse than no decisions. Track what was decided, follow up on execution.

Be transparent. Public dashboards, open documents, accessible records. Operations should be visible.

Document everything. The next operations person needs to pick up where you left off without a brain dump.

Celebrate the boring. Operations work is rarely exciting. Find satisfaction in the machine running smoothly.

Common Mistakes

- **Becoming a bottleneck.** If everything flows through you, you're a single point of failure.
- **Perfectionism.** Good enough today beats perfect next month.
- **Invisible work.** If others don't know what operations does, they won't appreciate it (or help).
- **Scope creep.** Operations can expand to fill all available time. Set boundaries.
- **Neglecting handoff.** Documentation debt accumulates. Pay it down continuously.

Transition Between Roles

Handoff Protocol

When rotating out of a role:

1. **Document current state** - What's in progress? What's pending? What's blocked?
2. **Brief incoming Pioneer** - Walk through active items, share context that isn't written down
3. **Remain available** - First two weeks of new rotation, be ready to answer questions
4. **Let go** - After two weeks, it's their role. Trust them.

Overlap Period

Rotations include 1-week overlap where both outgoing and incoming Pioneer share the role. This ensures continuity and knowledge transfer.

Feedback Loop

After completing a role rotation, briefly document:

- What worked well
- What you'd do differently
- Process improvements for future rotations

This accumulated wisdom improves the roles over time.

Summary

| Role | Core Question | Time | |-----|-----|-----| | **Mentorship** | How do I help this Architect succeed? | 3-5 hrs/wk | | **Evaluation** | Does this meet our standards? | 2-4 hrs/wk | | **Strategic Planning** | What decisions do we need to make? | 3-5 hrs/wk | | **Community Health** | How is the community doing? | 3-4 hrs/wk | | **Operations** | Is the machine running smoothly? | 4-6 hrs/wk |

You'll do all five. Each develops different muscles. Together, they make you a complete organizational steward.

"The best leaders don't create followers. They create more leaders."

— Tom Peters

"Smooth operations are invisible. You only notice when things break."

— The Architect